supplies through regular purchase and also through donations were ensured so that the health support system in the jail could be beefed up.

The statement of petitions and suggestions posted on all notice boards at the end of the year was indicative of the effect that this move had. Complaints about medical benefits and facilities had gradually petered down from 231, in June 1993, to a paltry 27 in December 1994. And, simultaneously, the number of referrals to hospitals had also been drastically reduced.

The highlight of the medical care programme came on 26 January (Republic Day) 1994. This day was celebrated by Tihar as Medical Care Day. Over 500 medical and paramedical staff visited the jail along with sophisticated medical equipment. Renowned specialists in various fields and in different schools of medicine spent the day at Tihar. Almost each and every one of the 9500 prisoners, including the children, were given thorough check-ups. Different coloured cards were handed over to the prisoners, which would clearly indicate whether a patient required specialized treatment or not. This classification would facilitate the regular medical staff of the prison to keep tabs on the individual prisoner's health status.

The then minister of health, Government of Delhi, Dr Harsh Vardhan, himself an ENT specialist, examined a large number of prisoners, with the IG (P) not missing her chance of availing this opportunity.

The follow-up to this programme was the establishment of continuing visits by VENU, a voluntary organization for eye care. Similarly, the Hope Foundation pursued a programme of dental care in the prisons. Education on AIDS was another continuing programme. A New Delhi-based NGO worked in the prisons with the conviction that behavioural changes were taking place in the younger generation because of modern-day stresses. The negative impact of such stresses, it felt, could be corrected by homoeopathic drugs and through proper counselling.

Further tie-ups with the medical community were seen, and the modalities for regular visits by various specialists were worked out.

Along with medicare, the problems relating to food and hygiene were also looked into. Prisoners were being provided just two meals a day comprising chappatis and dal or vegetables and monotonously at that. Breakfast comprised two slices of bread with tea with a weekly ration of eggs included. Rice pudding or *kheer* once a week was included in the menu. The quality of the foodstuff was also ascertained and it was ensured that the items were supplied only by the government's own Super Bazaar.

Dayal Singh, who had served more than 13 years of his 14-year sentence, of which six-and-a-half years were spent in the kitchen or *langar*, very confidently stated: 'Yes, when I shall be released I will be able to handle even big dinners for marriage parties. I think I have plenty of experience now.'

And why not? For he was a part of the team that cooked lunch and dinner daily for his jail comprising 2500 plus hungry stomachs out of a total of 9500 plus inmates.

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A harsh reality was that a number of prisoners succumbed to cholera over the years. The source of this scourge was the imponderable menace of the garbage being accumulated every day within the jail campus. With over 9500 people living in a closed environment, this garbage assumed catastrophic dimensions. As a result of mismanagement this garbage had been left to rot and had become a putrid mountain of filth and muck. The municipal authorities were requested by the present prison administration to clear out this garbage in their trucks. The authorities only hummed and hawed and finally pulled out on grounds of escalating financial burden to them. The state department was then